

Burying the hatchet: Virat Kohli and Naveen-ul-Haq exchanged handshakes during the latter stages of India's World Cup run chase against Afghanistan, putting the IPL fracas behind them. PTI

main aim is to work hard, be disciplined, and stay focused. In the past, these are the things that have worked for me. Apart from that, the support of my family and friends has been immense. They have been kind and contributed greatly to my journey.

Your decision to quit ODI cricket at the age of 24 surprised many. Was it a forced decision or a planned move?

(Smiles) Just before the ODI World Cup, I had a knee injury, and the decision to retire from the one-dayers was subject to that.

How do you motivate yourself to be part of Afghanistan's historic white-ball bilateral series against India, considering the six-year gap since making its Test debut against them in 2018?

The series is motivating for all players. It's historic. We hope to play India and other teams more often to gain confidence. This year's T20 World Cup [in the USA and the West Indies] is approaching [in June], so we hope to gain experience from this series that will help us during the tournament.

Afghanistan head coach Jonathan Trott has urged the cricket boards around the world to play more bilateral series against your side. What are your thoughts?

As mentioned by the coach, it has been a challenge for many teams, including Afghanistan, to find opponents to play against. Some major teams do not have space in their Future Tours Programme (FTP) to schedule matches against us. It is a commendable initiative by the BCCI and the Afghanistan Cricket Board to organise the first-ever bilateral series against India. Hopefully, this will be the start of many more series against

India and other big nations. Such opportunities would help us improve our performance at ICC events. It's a global game, and things should be equal for every full-member side. That's what many cricketing nations think, so I feel this is a new start for Afghanistan cricket, and after our performance in the ODI World Cup, many big teams will now be willing to play against us.

Would you say that the 2023 ODI World Cup took Afghanistan cricket ahead by a mile?

It was a historic World Cup in many ways. Since the 2015 World Cup, where we just had one victory against Scotland, we have not been able to win in any other editions. But in the 2023 edition of the tournament, we had four wins, and we narrowly missed out on the semifinal spot. It's a big step for Afghan cricket. Earlier, Afghanistan cricket was only known for its expertise in T20s, but this was quite a significant change for people to see during the ODI World Cup.

Ever since making your debut for Afghanistan, you have been known to wear your heart on your sleeve.

As a cricketer, it is an individual's choice whether to display emotions on the field. Every time I represent my country, club, or franchise, I put

my heart and soul into the game, and that commitment will remain with me until I retire. As a cricketer, you will inevitably experience ups and downs in your career, and it's important to accept and embrace these challenges and continue to enjoy the game. Playing style is a personal choice, and everyone has their unique approach. I won't change my style of play, even if it appears different to those watching from the outside. It is not necessary to justify our actions to others.

As a young cricketer, how do you manage social media trolls and their impact on your game, especially considering the controversy with Virat Kohli during IPL 2023?

I don't have a problem with trolling and I don't see it as a negative thing. I have a friends and family group on WhatsApp where I share the memes I receive during the IPL. To me, these memes are just harmless jokes and don't bother me at all. They even motivated me to play well during the IPL and the World Cup.

But eventually, you and Kohli patched up...

(Laughs) Yes. I had a bit of a chat with him during and after the game in the ODI World Cup. So, there was nothing personal between us. It all happened in the heat of the moment.



Morale booster: Afghanistan players celebrate the dismissal of Englishman Mark Wood during the ICC World Cup in 2023. The Afghans were on a giant-killing spree in the tournament before being blown away by a Glenn Maxwell blitzkrieg.

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